

Smarter than Thou

Today, mobile phones aren't bought to make calls.
You're only as cool as your instrument, so buy carefully...

Watching TV the other day, I was bombarded by ads that featured state-of-the-art smartphones. Especially catchy was the Nokia 6600 and whatever came with it, including a promotion and a girlfriend. That really had me itching to go out and get one for myself. And well, it was about time I sent my Nokia 3310 to the museum anyway.

With that in mind, I dashed off to Mumbai's mecca of all things gizmotic—Heera Panna at Haji Ali. Making my way through the crowds of window-shoppers, I walked into the shop that had the most models on display. The smiling chap at the counter introduced himself as Amit, and asked what I wanted.

I meekly asked for a phone that had a camera and some other stuff thrown in, such as Bluetooth, GPRS and radio, and if possible an MP3 player. Pat came the reply, “*Budget kitna hai?*”, which in consumer-speak roughly translates to, “How big a hole in your pocket do you want to burn?”

Lying through my teeth, I told him that money was no object, and that I wanted a phone that would take care of my needs and look good.

A Nokia 6600 was placed in front of me, the same one I'd seen on TV: it was Rs 21,500. Latest *maal*, and the most selling at this time. Camera, organiser, Bluetooth—the works. Ah well, don't you have anything better than this, I



said. He went on to show me a Sony Ericsson P900, one of the best smartphones available today: Rs 35,000. Anything similar, I prodded further. Sure, the Siemens SX1 at Rs 27,000 was available. Giving Amit the ‘maybe I'll buy it’

look, I began to scour around for more exotic choices.

Soon enough, I found one that had the 02 XDA on display, for Rs 45,000. The 02 XDA features Pocket PC tools such as Word, Excel and Media Player, and has an Intel StrongARM 32-bit processor with 64 MB of RAM, plus expandability options.

Needless to say, I was hooked. But this was more of a PDA than a phone. And it didn't have Bluetooth. I asked the friendly guy at the counter if he had anything else. He could only churn out some Sony Cliés and a Zire 71, which didn't interest me.

So my journey continued. In another shop, I got to look at the Handspring Treo 600, which has not yet been officially introduced in India. At Rs 36,000, it was priced like the Sony P900, but features such as Bluetooth were missing. The Tungsten W was Rs 22,000, but again there were drawbacks. Like most of its counterparts, it lacked Bluetooth. Plus, you can only speak into the phone if you attach the headset, and the processor is slow.

This was more than enough research for me, and I got back to where Amit sat smiling. I asked him to show me the Nokia 6600 and the Sony Ericsson P900. I had narrowed the choices down to these two, though the Siemens SX1 does have features similar to the P900. The 6600 is a definite looker and also has features, but it can't record video for more than 9 seconds. Plus, on the P900, you can flip open the keypad so the full screen is viewable; you can also take videos horizontally.

Yes, the Sony Ericsson was worth it. I asked about the warranty. Amit's basic premise was I would get a one-year repair warranty, but no replacement. So I asked for an absolutely new piece which was brought in and given to me right out of the box, which I checked to ensure that all was right, before paying and making my exit from the place.

Amit was still smiling. ■



■ Before you splurge on a smartphone, make sure you really need it.

If you need a mobile phone, get a mobile phone. If you need to take notes at the drop of a hat, or if you need to check out stock prices on the go, get a smartphone.

■ If you're getting a really worthwhile features, but need to spend a couple of thousands more, go for it.

■ Make sure the features on your smartphone include options for easy connectivity with your PC, and expansion options such as memory cards.

■ Take your time to check all the functions, because in the shop is the only time you can get a replacement if something doesn't work right. If the mobile stops working even the very next day, you can only get it repaired, not replaced.